

Yassine Lahbichi – lahbichi

Praxis Diary

The way I define engineering

Position Statement

The way I define engineering

When: January 6th

Where: Praxis Studio II - Toronto

I don't think design is simply solving problems. It's choosing which problems deserve attention, understanding the people affected, and building solutions that still matter once the moment passes. Design is making intentional choices to create an outcome that matters.

On the other hand, engineering is the discipline of turning constraints into advantages. Those constraints could be rules of nature (science) or just design constraints given by the stakeholders.

So basically, engineering design is a structured, iterative process that turns human needs into reliable solutions under real-world constraints.

In other words, it's not only "build a solution."

Moreover, I believe engineers should choose the most responsible problems they can, and always consider who benefits from what they build. These same engineers will have the consequences of what they build.

That's why I keep coming back to energy. Energy is one of the biggest problems on Earth: it decides whether regions develop or stay behind, whether industries can grow, and sometimes, whether countries stay stable or fall into conflict. Energy is a foundation for peace, education, healthcare, and opportunity.

If I contribute to the energy field one day, I won't just be "doing engineering." I'll be helping people for the future. Like killing two birds with the same stone, but in a much better way: immediate help and long-term stability.

Design note:

Engineering design = service + responsibility + long-term impact.

Leo Club taught me that service is a system

When: High school times

Where: Leo Club Days - Casablanca, Morocco

This mindset didn't come from lectures. It came from real experience, especially through what I experienced in the Leo Club.

Leo Club was my high school volunteering club affiliated with the Lions Club, and I was the President of the Action and Logistics Department. Being in charge of logistics made me realize something important: service is not a single act. It's coordination, consistency, and impact. Helping people isn't just "having a good heart." It requires building a system that actually works, as an engineer would do.

One of the clearest moments for me was organizing large-scale community clean-up initiatives in a forest in the suburbs of the city, next to my region's landfill. At first, we thought that it would be a simple action. But the second we started planning, it turned into a real design challenge: mobilizing volunteers, transporting equipment, dividing roles, ensuring safety, keeping motivation high, and adapting to constraints like time limits or changing conditions.

However, here, the design wasn't only technical. It was human; it needed to come from the desire to truly resolve the issue.

Design note:

Engineering design → Project that comes from the heart.

Project that comes from the heart → Engineering design.



Iteration: how failure became what made me win

When: Still high school times

Where: Fundraising Season - Casablanca, Morocco

Over time, the Leo Club taught me something else: iteration.

We organized more than one fundraising gala, and each time, the event improved because we treated mistakes as lessons. Problems that felt unavoidable at first became predictable later. We learned how to plan for incidents, anticipate failure points, and build projects that stayed reliable under pressure.

Each iteration made us stronger, not because we worked harder, but because we worked smarter. We understood constraints better. We adapted the system, and nothing could be achieved without my teammates.

For our first fundraising gala, we booked an event hall in the suburbs, far from the high school audience we were targeting, because it was cheaper. But then, we got hit by a sandstorm that day. Transportation became difficult, fewer people came, and profit dropped.

It was a hard but constructive lesson: the “best solution on paper” isn’t always the best solution in reality.

So for the next event, we moved the gala closer to our stakeholders. More accessible, more aligned with the people we wanted to reach. It changed everything.

That’s when I started interpreting design differently: stakeholders must be a primary goal to respect; a solution is never final; and success is not perfection, it is improvement.

Design note:

Failure isn’t the opposite of success bro, just chill out.



The values I carry into engineering design

When: Snow day

Where: Chestnut Residence - Toronto

Looking back at these experiences, my values in engineering design became clear.

I prioritize long-term impact because temporary solutions can hide deeper problems.

I prioritize service because design should improve lives, not impress my résumé or just earn money.

I prioritize sustainability, because engineering without environmental responsibility is not innovation, it's delay.

And I prioritize teamwork, because no meaningful solution is ever built alone.

These values affect how I frame problems. They shape the questions I naturally ask:

- Who does this serve?
- What happens later?
- This couldn't be improved?

Design note:

Values decide what success even means.

Basketball: how I learned to design strategically

When: Still high school times, when I had time to play basketball...

Where: Court lessons - Casablanca, Morocco

Values alone aren't enough. Design also needs a method. And strangely, a lot of my method comes from basketball.

Basketball taught me to treat performance as a cycle of observation, strategy, and adaptation. Winning isn't about repeating the same move. It's reading the environment, understanding teammates, anticipating opponents (constraints), and adjusting in real time.

I learned to scan the court constantly:

What's working? What's failing? What risks are showing up? What opportunities are opening? How can I contribute to team dynamics?

Even learning by copying and improving techniques from others isn't imitation. It's disciplined growth. It's learning patterns that work, then refining them into your style.

One strategy I'm proud of is what I did in losing scenarios. Instead of rushing to score the winning point, I would slow the pace. I'd fade into the background, make myself inconspicuous, let the defense forget me, then receive a pass and score efficiently.

That move taught me something deep: being smart beats being loud.

That's engineering too. The best designers aren't those who insist on originality at all costs. They're the ones who observe, learn fast, iterate intelligently, and think about durable solutions.

Design note:

Strategy in design = observe + adapt + choose the right path.



My personal engineering design process (the loop)

When: Snow Day, right after

Where: I can't really study anywhere else, so I guess Chestnut - Toronto

At this point, I realize I see engineering design like a team sport played with purpose.

It starts with observing and interpreting: reading constraints, stakeholder needs, and context.

Then comes alignment: communicating with teammates, making sure we share the same objective, and reviewing existing solutions for inspiration and constraints.

Then it becomes strategic action: proposing ideas, testing them, choosing what works.

And finally, it requires reflection: learning honestly from outcomes, then iterating.

Design note:

Observe → Align → Act → Reflect → Iterate.

The kind of engineer I want to become

When: Snow Day, but laaaaaater

Where: Somewhere in the future, if I survive this weather

Ultimately, I want to pursue engineering as a way of creating meaningful change. Working in the energy field is a direct extension of humanitarian work. It's helping on a larger scale by addressing one of the most critical challenges of our time.

My position as an engineer designer is rooted in service and guided by strategy. I design by observing, aligning, acting, and iterating, aiming not only to succeed today, but to build a better future.

Design note:

Engineering as a career = humanitarian work on a larger scale.

